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Harold Danko

Harold Danko is an accomplished pianist, composer, and jazz educator. He was a faculty member of Eastman School of Music and served as the head of the jazz program there for eleven years. His 2021 CD release, "Spring Garden," on SteepleChase Productions demonstrates Harold's fascination with Stravinsky's "Rite of Spring."

Harold was interviewed via Zoom on April 28, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm pleased to have Harold Danko with me today, who is a pianist, composer, and professor emeritus at Eastman School of Music. And I probably left some things out but maybe we'll get to that.

HD: Thanks for having me.

MR: Thank you.

HD: I refer to myself and say "a promising septuagenarian pianist" you know. I usually apply that adjective to prodigies.

MR: Yes.

HD: But I'm still promising. I don't know what I'm promising.

MR: Okay. Well you've still got a ways to go then, in your own mind.

HD: Hopefully.

MR: Yeah. I prepared a longer-than-normal question here, so you'll have to put up with me for a moment. You were born in 1947?

HD: Correct.

MR: Okay. So in 1959 there was actually a documentary called "The Year that Changed Jazz" and in that year you had the release of "Kind of Blue," "Time Out," Mingus "Ah Um," "The Shape of Jazz to Come." At the same time on the pop charts you had Johnny Horton's "The Battle of New Orleans," and "Kansas City" by Wilbert Harrison. So my question is did a 12-year-old Harold Danko take note of any of this music, and did it affect you in any particular way? If not, what did?

HD: Well you know that's about the year I really got interested in jazz and it was thanks to, I had two older brothers, both played saxophone, and so there was jazz in the house but they were much older than me and so they were not living at home, and I was the kid who they would come over and we would play some standard tunes or whatever. I didn't know much. But then my brother got one of those big stereo things and played "Milestones" actually. And that did it for me. I heard "Milestones" on a stereo where

Coltrane and whatever, and that was it. It was life-changing. It might have been, it might have been right in 1959 or '60 because yeah, it had to be. Because "Milestones" "Kind of Blue" was just going to come out I think. And my brother got me that record for that Christmas. And so all those records you mentioned, plus the rock stuff and all the things I was listening to — I mean Chuck Berry was, you know when I saw him on "American Bandstand" that changed my life too. I saw a guy doing the duck walk or whatever it was, I said that's the coolest thing you know, we don't do that in Masury, Ohio you know. And so all those things were really influential. And not to be too long-winded about it but in my own, you know my own sense of creativity or whatever, those were much more important, including the rock side of that, and the jazz instrumentals that I heard, than the standard repertoire, even though I was learning standard repertoire. The words didn't mean that much to me in the standard repertoire. When I hear something like I get no kick from champagne I mean I didn't get it you know. And I hadn't been to a musical or anything like that. So some of that repertoire didn't affect me as much as just whatever Miles was doing, and whatever I was hearing the instrumentalists do. And then the other side of it was because my contemporaries growing up with kids who were interested in the rock and basically funk styles that came out and so that was very influential, plus you know the Beatles and that sort of thing later on. The Beatles, Frank Zappa, all those things in the 60s, all my friends were into that. And I just loved it. And then the more I got interested in playing and got into bands, because I just wanted to be part of a band. That was like the greatest thing. I think when I was 15 or 16 I played a gig at an actual club and we were trying to be the John Coltrane Quartet I think or something you know. And that was just the greatest thing, to be part of a band. And then I realized the value of all those standard tunes that I had kind of grown up with because I did hear the radio, I heard Sinatra and heard all these things. And once in a while I liked the tune. But like I said, the words never got to me. You know for me, you know Bob Dylan "Masters of War" got to me more you know. I could get into that. That was my generation. Or "Eleanor Rigby."

MR: Yes.

HD: Those kind of things were poetic to me.

MR: The words sort of came from a previous generation. It probably was a good thing that at age 12 you didn't know about getting a kick from champagne I suppose.

HD: I guess so, yeah, yeah I didn't know about that yet.

MR: But I think it's so terrific that the Miles LP you mentioned, you know it starts out so ear-catching, like [scats]. How can that not grab you?

HD: Yeah. Especially on a big stereo you know. It was just amazing. And then there's so

— like I think there's three things that are blues on the record. And then there's that Red Garland thing "Billy Boy" which is kind of doing Ahmad Jamal but it's with Philly Joe Jones so you know that's some thrilling stuff you know.

MR: Yes indeed. Do you remember the first gig where you ever made money and how much was it?

HD: Absolutely. It was the — well now I think of it there was a couple of ways. Actually my brother Joe taught saxophone and would give — his students would give a recital once a year, I think when I was about 13 or 14 he started paying me to accompany them so that I got money for actually trying to learn and these, whatever the accompaniment parts were to these saxophone solos. Basically an intermediate kind of level.

MR: Classical?

HD: What's that?

MR: Was it classical?

HD: Yeah kind of, whatever saxophonists study you know. I remember "Flight of the Bumblebee" or something I don't know. But he had a bunch of clarinet students. So that was the first paying gig that I had. But then that quartet gig I mentioned which was at a real jazz club, you know, with alcohol and actually marijuana outside in the car. And I was like 16 or something. And my dad would drop me off to the gig and I realized I was in another world in this club. And then my dad picked me up at 2:00. You know like things had changed a lot, at 2:00 in the morning. But we were playing "Impressions" and we were trying to do this kind of stuff. And it was pretty amazing, that feeling of being in a band and actually getting paid for playing music. Because I came up in a steel-working town. My father started out in the coal mines in Pennsylvania and he was a steel worker in Sharon, Pennsylvania. I grew up in Masury, Ohio, just across the state line. But my father worked in a plant and it was a big deal to escape the mills you know. And so music was a way out. And my parents were very musical. My dad played the button accordion in a Slovak style, polkas. And actually my older brother Joe played some button accordion too but was a saxophonist and clarinetist, a music teacher by trade too.

MR: I assume you had a piano in the house?

HD: Yeah. My brother was finishing his college degree when I was about 5 or 6 years old, or he was in college and he moved a piano into our house, and there was a piano because he needed it for whatever you need to do to pass piano in college. So there it was. And Joe showed me middle C and some notes, and kind of from there got to some lessons, and then trying to pick out tunes.

MR: Did your father, he played a button accordion?

HD: Yeah, what do they call those, harmonium, or — it's a button accordion, you know the

MR: Well I'm wondering, when did the idea of playing, creating music from chord changes come — when were you confronted with that?

HD: Well the legend in my house is that my brother Joe early on in the Swing Era, because he started playing in clubs back when he was about 12 or 13, back in the war years because, in the second World War. So he started making good money, and the legend in the house was that he traded in some of my dad's polka records for a Benny Goodman record. And so that brought jazz into the house. And there was still enough polka records laying around, so jazz was in the house and between my brother Joe, who was older and very influential, but also my brother John who played alto and was very melodic. There are some tapes that I have that are very precious where John sounds kind of like Paul Desmond. I mean he just had a natural sense of melody. And so both Joe and John were really into this standard repertoire. So there was a fake book around, or whatever, you know they called them fake books in those days. And so somehow probably Joe showed me some chords or whatever, 'cause he was doing that. And so that's the idea of, like my brothers would be coming over and like I said they were married by this time and out of the house, but maybe on a Saturday they would come around, and maybe on their way to a gig. And so they might need a little warm-up or something, so they came and ran through a couple of standard tunes, and whatever it would be, and I'd be reading them you know chords in root positions, whatever I knew. So that idea of playing by chords and playing by ear was around. Plus my dad was a — just — he was not a trained musician so he played whatever he knew by ear.

MR: Um hum. There's a lot to be said for playing by ear, isn't there?

HD: Absolutely, yeah, yeah. It's really one of those things where I'm really glad I had that — I wish I had been a little more disciplined about reading because it was one of those things where I tried to hear it and I talked about — I was explaining once about I could never be ear-blind. There was a teacher when I was about 16 I went to study with a wonderful teacher named Dolores Spitzer who had me sight read something that was on the piano. And after a couple of bars she said, "You don't read, do you?" And she said, "You try to figure it out." And I said that's exactly right, you know like and she said, "You've got to just read the next note like the paper, like you're reading." And I just like had this concept, I just can't do it ear-blind. I've got to know kind of what it sounds like or how does it function you know. And so as I went along I could kind of sight read Mozart, I could kind of sight read Scott Joplin. But the music that I really like is very dissonant and so I really had a problem reading stuff that was, you know I had to analyze it first.

MR: It sort of brings me to the question of when you play, when you have played classical

piece, like what is the composer doing here. I mean I know in the past I've had little assignments where I might look at a score and go down vertically, see if I can make sense out of all the instruments. What's the chord here?

HD: Absolutely, yeah. That's the way, in my Beethoven sonatas my teachers at college would laugh because I had everything labeled G7 — and they would just — they couldn't believe it. I said if I don't know what it is per my own understanding, you know because I could get through the theory classes and call it a 5 – 7 or whatever, but for me it was like if it was a G7 it was a G7. And I said that helps me to fake it if I have to. And I remember one particular jury I did where I was convinced I was going to flunk because whatever — I was playing and my teacher, Robert Hopkins at that time, at Youngstown University, said, I ended up with a B minus or something. And they said we passed you because we couldn't believe you kept going on. And I just said yeah, that's those chords. I know where I am if I'm making every mistake I still can track and I know where I am in the piece. It should have been an A7 there, it wasn't.

MR: But that's so much better than stopping, right?

HD: Oh yeah. That's the reason they passed — I think I would have been out of music school if I had stopped you know. But I looked at the jury and they had this horrified — both of my teachers, because Dolored Spitzer was on that jury and Robert Hopkins. And they just — her jaw was dropped. You know when I got up I said I'm out of here. I know I'm gone. And then when I ended up with whatever, I think it was a B minus, it was the lowest you could get where you wouldn't have to, you know, repeat it or something.

MR: I see.

HD: So they said, "We just couldn't believe it, that you got through it somehow," and I know where it's supposed to end.

MR: Well I'm going to leapfrog a bit. If you think about what you learned in those classes, in that environment, compared to what you might have learned on the Woody Herman band, can you compare and contrast that?

HD: Well I mean I'm really glad that I had that preparation and when I got with Woody's band, which was my first real, I would say, real professional gig you know, with some kind of people noticing it and you had to be on your toes, I at least had the background to do the reading, and I knew enough tunes. There was a little initiation test that Woody had, because there were some charts that were fake, the rhythm section — so my first gig, you know all the cynical guys on the — I had just gotten out of the Army so I was just the happiest guy with my short hair, to be on Woody Herman's band. And some of the guys would say, oh we were playing like an Elks Club or something, my first gig, one of those things. And the guys were saying, "Every night's a jazz festival" you know. So we

whatever, "just do the gig" and whatever. And so Joe LaBarbera, who had gotten me on the gig, said oh by the way, some of the charts, like there's no rhythm charts on like "Satin Doll" and "A Train." He said, "Do you know those Duke Ellington intros on those?" And I said, "Yeah, pretty much I could do it on 'Satin Doll'" or whatever. He said, "Good, because Woody will just count it off and that's what you do for the intro." And not knowing it's like really the initiation test, the first tune with Woody Herman he just like walked on and kind of had a look at me, ah there's a new piano player, number 300 or whatever. And he says, "Satin Doll intro, one, two" and I went [scats] and it's like I looked at Joe LaBarbara and it was like okay, you'll be on the gig I think, you know.

MR: Nice.

HD: So I guess if you just played a 1-6-2-5 or whatever, 1-4-3-6 even, it wouldn't have made it.

MR: I see. That's so fascinating that, how musicians get plugged into those bands, like there's no rehearsal, it's like you're thrown into the fire and you hope you survive I guess.

HD: And the guy who recommended you's ass is on the line. So Joe LaBarbara's ass —

MR: Oh yeah.

HD: You know. When I got the gig with Liza Minelli for a while, which is 1979, which I was definitely the 15th call or something because they had asked Lawrence Feldman my friend. They got to the saxophones to ask about piano players. And so Lawrence Feldman recommended me. So you know when a saxophone player is recommending you that they've gone down the list of people. But all these guys were studio guys in New York and didn't want to travel. So I got a chance to do that, get very well paid for a little while, and see some show business.

MR: Did you have to be ready to play songs that you knew in different keys with Liza or with female singers?

HD: Sure. Absolutely yeah that was part of the fun for me. At the beginning I was not a very good transposer. You know if I knew that I had to do it I would write out a quick lead sheet or at least the chords in other keys. But then it got to be where most of the tunes I knew well enough, especially if there was a chart I mean it was not a problem. But I remember one night with Liza there was an intro, I gave her a D7 and we used to just — because she could be very spontaneous and funny. But the show was very scripted. It was the same every night. When something would happen, like when part of the stage would fall down and she'd ad lib, we'd just love it. So, and she was very cool that way, she was really very cool. And then one night I gave her the D7 which was supposed to go to "Someone to Watch Over Me" or something, I think in G. So I gave her whatever the chord was, and she went into another tune in G. And I was right there. And that was

winging it. You know she was taking a slight liberty, and thank goodness I knew the tune. You know. But I mean most singers had charts and it would be, I remember Anita O'Day was a bit difficult because she would do verses and really just run right through the verse. And I wouldn't have the words, it would be a tune I didn't know the words to the verse. And she'd have like somebody had done a lead sheet with the melody but that's not what she did. She was just running right through it to get to whatever it was. And so finally I just told her, like because she was screaming at me, you know like whatever. Anita would scream and I was old enough to kind of scream back. And I said, "Just tell me the word you want the chord on and I'll be there." You know so we actually did that. So the word whatever, okay chord here. So and then I'd catch her on the word rather than try to read this thing. And she's running through it, and then oh we're already in the tune you know. So yeah those were, that was one of the more difficult things, but it got resolved. Somebody just sent me, I went to Brazil with Anita O'Day and somebody just sent me an audio of it. I could send it to you. And she's doing a lot of ballads. It's kind of interesting, I guess it's 1984, and she's not in the greatest shape, you know, vocally, but there are times when it was magic, really, because the time and whatever, that was her thing. And so that was one of the more difficult gigs that I did because she was in a certain place I think in her life and then I think things got a little better for her after that.

MR: Playing for singers, did that bear fruit when you started playing for Chet Baker and Lee Konitz? They're both such great melodists.

HD: I guess like the time with Chet, which was right after Woody Herman, was just the first time I played with him, the first few years when I was on the road, I didn't do the records that he was doing at that point because that was CTI sort of thing that he was involved with so they used Bob James and whoever was the house rhythm section. But that was an education because he sang and played, you know, he did everything. And previous to that I'd done some singers in Ohio. I worked with Maureen McGovern when she was a kid. We had a — she was a singer in the group, but she was pretty folk oriented in her own way. She played guitar and sang. But I remember, and I think she credits me with it, I turned her on to "Spring Can Really Hang You Up the Most," I said, you've got to learn this tune you know. And so I think she acknowledged me for that one time when I saw her twenty, thirty years ago. She says, "Yeah you're the one that brought that tune up." So other than her and a few good singers back in Ohio it was Chet who really set me up for anything that I would learn later on about accompanying because his stuff was just so straightforward and it was the right stuff all the time. And even when his chops on trumpet weren't there he'd sing the next phrase. Or he'd sing and then play the trumpet

sang just to set the mood basically. That's the only reason he said he sang. He wanted to set that mood and then kind of retain that mood for those eight minutes or whatever. And that was important for me to understand, to not try to play everything I know on a ballad or something, just like stay there and then let the next tune be its thing too.

MR: I see. Was — did you have a career choice dilemma early on? So I'm backtracking a bit but was there a point as a young man where you had something else you considered doing besides being a professional musician?

HD: Well early on in high school I was fairly good at writing. I was a fairly decent journalist. And I had good teachers in Brookfield High School, I'll give them a plug, in Ohio. But so it was kind of expected — I did music on my own because I wasn't in marching band or anything, because when you're a pianist you do that, and then eventually I joined the chorus because there were some nice looking girls and whatever you know, I thought I could say hi and have the hope of whatever you know. But other than chorus, some of the teachers didn't even know what I played so there was an expectation that I might go into journalism and whatever. But I always felt that writing was hard for me. I could do it pretty well and it served me very well especially in my academic career when I was the chairman at Eastman for eleven years and whatever, and had to write certain things. And even like I've written some articles and whatever. So I can write but it's a lot of effort for me, even like the liner notes that I did, I do them sometimes for records just so I can get people on the track. Because sometimes the liner notes, when they're written by somebody who has another agenda, might not focus the listener the way I might want to. So sometimes I write my own liner notes. So that was a possibility but early on like from getting those paying gigs I realized I could do this and I realized that it was better than working in the mill. My dad had got me a job my first summer after I started college in the mill. And between the loudness of the sound, and you know you could take home some money at that time from working in the mill, compared to other things, but it was just so loud and so hard, and I saw how hard my dad worked running a hand crank by a blast fur — and I said this is not for me. And that was exactly his intention. Like I did six weeks and I just said okay that's a real eliminated possibility and then you know the thing with my parents is like get a degree, teach music like my brother Joe, so you know you get out doing that. So teaching was kind of another option that I had that as I got towards the end of my college career and did my student teaching actually, I kind of eliminated that possibility. Had a few lesson plans and then the lesson plans were never like what was going on. I did this lesson plan, I'm winging it here you know.

MR: Which is worst a blast furnace or junior high music class?

HD: Yes exactly. And so I said well I remember I was just kind of learning the diminished

not getting a teaching gig, and I got my draft notice right away, in 1969. So but I auditioned in Indianapolis, figuring that's close enough to Ohio, maybe I can hang in there, you know a six hour drive and whatever. And the guy in Indianapolis was very great. He had me sit in, the audition was sitting in with his big band. And he said, "You play too well, you don't want to come and be in a fort band." He said, "the only thing the Army can offer you is a location." I went hmm okay. He said if you ever want to go to Europe, want to travel someplace, and I said, "Is there any place in New York?" "Oh yeah there are bands in New York." So he made a call to a Staten Island band, it was a fort band located in Staten Island. They said they had openings. They had actually, the officers really weren't running it, it was like an enlisted guy that answered the phone. They already had like four or five piano players. But he said yes so I got a chance to go to Fort Wadsworth in Staten Island. And after Basic Training, and kind of, get into this band, that already had piano players. And great, really wonderful musicians at that time. So that was a kind of a continuation of my education. Near the end of my Army career another option came about when, because at the end of the, it was 1972 and there was a lot of, you know that anti-war thing, whatever that was going on, and the people that were getting out of the Army, the Army was suddenly allotting money to train people in a trade. So I said oh wow, piano tuning. Maybe I can get a piano tuner, or whatever. So there was a thing where they said, "Well you already have a degree in whatever, in music." I said, "I've got to get into a trade." So I went on the lookout for a piano tuner and then there was somebody that had done woodwind repair with Saul Fromkin in New York. He was a woodwind repairman that was very well known. And so I called Saul asking if he knew any piano tuners that I could — and he said, "Oh you should do woodwind repair." Of course he's going to get some money from the Army to train me. And I said, "Well I don't really play the woodwinds." He said, "It's better, it's like you'll be scientific" or whatever. So I went in and I learned how to repair woodwinds. I was pretty awful at it. I was very slow. But Saul entrusted me to repair some student metal clarinets every now and then. And once he gave me an open holed flute, uh, which took me forever to re-pad. But anyway I had some skill going there, which actually served me well in Woody Herman because Tom Anastas who as the baritone player used to warm up Woody's horn and there was something wrong. I don't know what Tom might have done with the horn but there was one time where it got a little bit out of line and I was able to look at it enough and get it so Woody would know there was something wrong but it wasn't horrible, like that anyone had thrown it or anything. But when I got back to New York there was the idea that maybe I would do this, you know this woodwind repair thing in addition to trying to make my way. So I did it, but it was one of those things

innate mechanical skill. So it was just, I did a few things on my own and then started just getting back into teaching privately, and that's kind of what I did for most of my New York career, I just taught a lot until a couple of institutions came along, Manhattan School of Music in the 80s and they were forming a jazz department and I was able to be on the ground floor of that. And then some other things that came my way, some adjunct things and some independent studies. So I was always able to kind of juggle the playing with my private students at that time.

MR: What do you consider in the 70s going into the 80s as really important musical associations for yourself, playing gigs and recording perhaps?

HD: Well definitely when I, you know my Chet Baker association, which went to about 1976 or so, and then during that time I also met Lee Konitz and started playing with him. There was a place called Striker's Pub on West 86th Street. So I met Lee Konitz and that was very influential. I had actually met Lee Konitz initially at Saul Fromkin's where he was a customer of Saul Fromkin but that was not, I met him as a woodwind repairman but then I met him later on and actually in the park walking our dogs because we were close to Central Park. I lived on the upper west side. But he lived right across the street from Striker's where I was playing a couple of nights with Chet Baker and then I started playing a couple of nights with Lee. Don Elliot started playing there, he's a mellophone player. And so I started playing there — well I was playing there because my electric piano was there. My Fender Rhodes.

MR: Your Fender Rhodes.

HD: So it was a horrible Fender Rhodes but it was in residence there so I did a lot of gigs at Striker's. So that was very good for me, and a lot of people do remember that club because it was pretty intimate and you know it was a chance to go hear Lee Konitz in a trio and he was pretty low profile at that point. You know I mean he was, well it was before he formed the nonet. And that was, he started getting some ideas about re-asserting himself on the scene I think, but he was not doing a whole lot other than these little gigs at Striker's and then maybe going out and doing whatever he'd get as a solo act picking up musicians. Then from that my peers — Gregory Herbert, a great saxophonist that I became friends with with Woody Herman, we had a group that we tried to organize. So there was a bunch of my contemporaries, Jimmy Madison, a great drummer in that time, so always trying to have little gigs of our own and then it was Gregory who recommended me to Thad and Mel. And I'd known Mel from some, I think he did a week with Chet Baker that I was on. So I had this shot to play with Thad Jones and the first gig I did with them was a quartet gig, Joyous Lake I think up in Woodstock, New York, something like that. And it was Sam Jones on bass, Mel Lewis, me and Thad. And it was

looking for somebody for the band." You know and I was like, and I truthfully didn't know a whole lot about the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band. I knew Thad as a player. I knew his Five by Five, the Monk records that he did and also what he did early on with Mingus, "The Jazz Experiments of Charles Mingus" where you know, so I knew Thad's playing. I didn't really know his writing, but I guess I comped in the places that was good — so anyway I had a shot to do the big band and Mel Lewis gave me a heads up on what charts they were doing, so I didn't have to go in and sight read on a Monday. I had the charts over the weekend or something, and then Mel said we're going to do this one and we're not going to do this, don't worry about that. And he said make sure, look at the ending of this one. So I had a little coaching from Mel. So that was the way I went in on my first Monday and did the big band, and that was a revelation, like now I mean sometimes when I go out to a college and do these Thad Jones charts, I would just try to be the piano player you know. But now I just totally appreciate what Thad, what he did with that band. And you know and it had also to do with Mel, because that whole chemistry of the way Mel played with that band. I played that music with other people, other drummers than Mel. And it's really like hmm, not quite.

MR: Not quite. That was a, we wore those records out in college, and still like what's the Jerome Richardson tune?

HD: "Groove Merchant"?

MR: "Groove Merchant." Oh my — man, that's like graduate school for saxophone players, right?

HD: Oh yeah, yeah. There's like, I mean it's everything and the freedom I had because I came into a place where the first pianist was Hank. So there was not a lot written for piano. I just did a clinic where we talked about one of those charts, "Don't Get Sassy." And what I explained to some students was that Sam Herman was the original guitar player in the band. And those charts look like guitar charts because they've got every chord because Sam is playing four to the bar on a lot of those things. And piano players don't play all that. But Hank was the first piano player so there's a lot of times in where Thad originally had C7, okay, then you hear the band play something and you say I'd better just play the third and the seventh you know and then figure out what Thad's doing. So that was the name of the game. And then if it looked like one of those charts that came out on Hal Leonard that are basically copies of what Sam Herman probably did for the rhythm section but basically what the guitar was doing in those early charts. Yeah. Just don't try to play all that, because like you'll be in the way.

MR: I feel sorry sometimes for high school piano players. They get these charts and there's all this piano stuff in the jazz band chart and you feel like — I have said this in the past and

it's not really fair, like just play half of that. "Well which half?" That's not really fair to them either but it's so over-written.

HD: Yeah. And sometimes it'll go, like it'll be a two staff thing with all the voicings written out, which is nice. But then it will go to some single staff with some slashes in it you know. So it's like really, it's one of those things where it comes down to your ears listening to it and then seeing where you might fit. With Thad I would find things where say I would come across like the band would be very tutti and then maybe I'd come across where I'd play a [hits note on piano] a bell tone, and Thad would be like [nods and grunts] you know kind of grunt. It's like keep that in. So that became like inventing a part you know that I would play. And then when I started strumming Thad gave me a nice grunt. I think I started strumming on "That's a Freedom," number one in the book. That's a Hank Jones chart. And I just started strumming four to the bar because there was no guitar there. And Thad grunted, mmm, keep that in. So that became like a little signature that I did that Roland Hanna before me, and nobody did, and Jim McNeely after me didn't do. So that little thing that I did that got the grunts, like keep that in, because it just maybe reminded him of maybe the early days of the band you know.

MR: Okay. Well this is sort of an open-ended question. In your own recordings and your own live concerts can you tell me what you realistically hope a listener gets from your playing?

HD: That's a very good question. I hope they get that I'm involved in that particular piece in that atmosphere of that piece and like trying to play from inside the music and whatever that suggests to try to keep it in that realm. And if the music is really crazy or outside well you play whatever. But if you're playing a ballad or if you're playing something to have a contrast within it and then for the person to really think okay this is good for that moment, like I'm enjoying, you know I'm enjoying what I'm hearing for that time. And so like from playing inside the piece and exploring what's there, and trying to put some signature on it but not trying to just impose everything that I might have practiced, because that just doesn't work for me. And for some guys they come in and they can nail whatever it is. But it kind of goes back a little bit to Chet Baker too where he would kind of, you know if he heard somebody who was just playing a lot of technique he was just kind of like hmm, what's that all about sort of. What does that have to do with what we started out with? So to keep it within that and I think that the listener should have a good experience with it and like doing things too long, doing things — I'm very conscious of that. And so I want somehow to include the listener. I'm not sure that I always do it but the intent is there.

MR: Would you ever, during an improvised solo on a standard tune, would you ever play a snippet of the melody perhaps, to remind the audience here's where we are, or something like that?

HD: Yeah sometimes, and some tunes just to remind myself too, to get back to see where I am. And I think keeping the melody close is very important. And also it's a reference point and if you can develop that, you know Lee Konitz had this kind of one to ten thing where if you're playing the melody that's number one and if you're playing something that's totally unlike the melody, you know if you're playing bebop maybe that's number five or number six. If you're playing really abstractly that's number ten, but you're still playing the tune. So Lee was very specific about saying yeah you should be able to play jazz at number two and number three, that that still sounds like jazz. Because a lot of people just have their prepared lick repertoire or whatever, and so they play the melody and then they go into whatever. And he said they're jumping maybe from number one to number six, and it's like so how do you — and so there's a thing that I'm on with Lee it's called "Portrait of a Saxophonist as an Artist" it's a video that we did in Canada. And Lee is trying to get this flute player to play something close to the melody. Because if you play these other things, and when he played close to the melody it didn't sound like jazz you know, it just sounded suddenly stiff. And so that's the point of that, and then funny in that video the next thing goes to Lee playing very abstractly on "Stella by Starlight" or something like that, just the most — but you know Lee had me singing Lester Young solos and Louis Armstrong. I basically did not study with Lee but in the course of rehearsing I got a lot of the things that he taught people. And he was very insistent on, like Lee once said, once told me I don't know I was playing "All the Things You Are" or something, and he accused me of using too much technique. I said man you want chops, there's a hundred guys in New York — I didn't say this but I'm thinking like you want chops? I'm not one of the chop guys. There's guys that will play rings around me. You want chops? So Lee said, "Well it should basically be able to play a good solo with one finger." And he'd be like [plays piano] whatever it was you know. So okay yeah. So one of the things I have to remind myself of, it came really in handy because the first time I played Carnegie Hall with Chet Baker, the first time in Carnegie Hall, I remember we were playing "Tidal Breeze" my tune. And I looked down and my knee was going up and down, I had this nervous thing. And I thought of that thing that Lee — I said I know my tune I can just kind of play the melody, I can play really close and just let the rhythm section groove. And then my knee calmed down and I was able to — but it was like one of those little nervous things, like the tic that could define your career. So that thing of being able to play it and have it sound like it's jazz but very simple. It's really hard, and

like let it be, you know like especially if you've got great players playing with you, you know you can lean on that. And sometimes we don't.

MR: Right. The better your accompaniment, your fellow musicians often times, the less you can get away with playing it seems like. Okay so you're a Stravinsky-ite I think I can say.

HD: I think so, yeah.

MR: So we could talk a bit about your release here. All right. You were very inspired by the "Rite of Spring" and I want to read, you said that you do fairly well with writing although it might be a chore for you. I want to read this thing in your liner notes, this is a quote: "smart ass that I am when once asked what my favorite song was by a local newspaper reporter I replied 'The Rite of Spring.'" And according to you you saved the shoes that you wore to Stravinsky's funeral service.

HD: Yeah. Pretty obsessive. No I realize it was 1971 — when he passed, you know I was still in the Army and a bunch of us guys were really into contemporary music and some guys had really studied Stravinsky. And I just knew it was the passing of a great. And I mean Coltrane, I missed that one, but there's something about Stravinsky passing that just — I said I've got to get in line here. And I paid my respects. And yeah I did save the shoes. The shoes were very uncomfortable. They were kind of a work boot looking thing that was kind of suede, it was from the 60s. And they were never comfortable. But I kept them and then finally I think at a yard sale I don't know somebody got them.

MR: Okay. They didn't know what they were getting.

HD: He's walking and he's wondering why it's going [bangs piano].

MR: "Why is it going like that when I walk?" Oh that's really good. Well I have a couple of comments about the recording, which I really liked, which I think can stand by itself as a recording or you can listen to it with "The Rite of Spring" in mind. And I wonder did you have that in mind or were you really trying to reflect Stravinsky as close as you could?

HD: No the thing, I realize with the quartet, especially we had a little rehearsal in Argentina, we got a chance to play again together. We hadn't played for some years. And I realized that it was going to have a personality of its own. And it wasn't like I could assign these guys, okay we're all going to listen to "The Rite of Spring" and then you come in with all the licks you can, we're going to just do this. It wasn't that, and I knew my fingers aren't on all the notes there, I'm just trying to grab things sometimes to refer to Stravinsky, so that's the way I wrote it for them. I wanted them to be who they are and with Rich Perry, Rich Perry is going to be Rich Perry and we hired him because of his great sound and you're going to know it's him, regardless of the music. So especially after we had our little rehearsal I just said this is going to go the way it's going to go and I'm just going to try to give some suggestions which we did. And then we left out some things. There were

ain't going to work, okay. And we needed to leave room for improvisation so it wasn't like I was going to be literal and try to play the whole score. And then there's just things like you know even that thing [bangs piano] there was no way I was going to play that exactly because I mean it could be played, and I know it, but I spaced it out in some way, just like gave a suggestion. So basically the comments from people I really respect have been very very good, I'm very pleased, because I think they got my idea and the fact that you know I wasn't going to just try to play the score.

MR: Can I ask you what that chord is?

HD: Oh yeah. It's an E [plays chord] triad in the left hand, and an E flat 7 in the right hand.

MR: You've got it surrounded.

HD: You've got it surrounded, yeah. There is a wonderful YouTube clip that's been looped of Stravinsky playing — if you've ever seen it — it's been looped and Stravinsky plays, it's like eight minutes of Stravinsky playing that chord and it's on a loop. But he's just enjoying it so much. And it's like he loved that chord. And then that sort of thing occurs later because he goes [bangs on piano] in a different key, you've got like the D7 on top and then the last one you've got E flat 7 in the bottom and a D 7 on top. So it's that sound that he's really intrigued with. Theoretically, nerd theory wise, I've seen this one other place, but my thing with it, I think it's that it's a 5 – 7 and a 6 —7 chord of A flat harmonic minor. Because you've got E flat 7 [plays chord]. But I've heard other explanations of it but you know to get my fingers on all those notes are in an A flat harmonic minor from whatever you want to call it, the flat sixth mode or the —

MR: Did Stravinsky, could he hear all that in his head do you think?

HD: I think so. I mean there's stories about him conducting and the wrong notes that he didn't catch in the score and whatever. I mean the thing that I, in reading about him, he did compose a lot at the piano. And there's one thing he wrote on one of the recordings that he conducted, he said that the last dance of "The Rite of Spring," the "Sacrificial Dance," he could play it before he could write it down. So that's kind of interesting. He was improvising, you know that sort of thing [plays dissonant piano] it's that kind of thing you're just having fun maybe, I don't know. It's a special kind of thing in 1912, I don't know. Nobody else was doing that.

MR: You know when — I've had the experience of hearing "The Rite of Spring" live twice and both times I felt like I'd been either run through a washing machine and hung up to dry, and all these like, and so I was really surprised to come across from his 1936 autobiography and I'm paraphrasing a little bit here but he said, "I consider that music is by its very nature essentially powerless to express anything at all. Expression has never been an inherent property of music." I go really?

HD: Pretty wild. I remember reading that a long time ago. And, okay. It's the way he — I mean I think it's like, he's like, at that point you know he's friends with Ravel, he's friends with Debussy. A lot of those kind of harmonies are present in Debussy a little less functional and Ravel almost functional. But Stravinsky puts the rhythmic element on it and kind of, I forget, you know he isolates these sounds away from a context of harmony. And I think that's like, you know rather than being totally atonal, when I found some of these things it's like wow, they're beautiful. There's like a thing where he goes [plays piano] it's just a dominant seventh chord, and then [plays snippett] there's a dominanty function but, you know, so I think the thing with jazz is that you know the diminished scale, the octatonic scale, whatever you want to call it. There's so much of that in it, and I think that that appeals to jazz musicians because there's so much of that sort of half/whole, whatever. And the diminished relationships. The thing, the architecture of the piece is something I found over time that's just fascinating to me, the way he uses things or just morphs them a little bit in another movement. You know things come back. And so at first you know I thought this is wonderfully random crazy stuff, how did he think of this. And then it's like as I studied it more and more it's like yeah, that's why it works, because we've maybe heard a little premonition of it someplace. And so he sets us up for that and it's a wild experience. I mean especially like with the tempos. My wife got me cognizant of this. There's some, I've heard some renditions of "The Rite of Spring" — the one that I got originally was Antal Dorati, the Minneapolis Symphony. And the tempos are swinging. And then there's some where the tempos are a little bit not so hot, because I've collected a bunch of scores. And my wife was the one that said well for the dancers maybe the stuff that I like the dancers, maybe it's too fast for the dancers. And as it got to become a concert piece, more than a dance piece — because I've never seen the whole dance. I don't think I've even seen it on-line. But you know the tempos might have to be a little bit slower for the dance to take place. Because it's very heavy dancing too.

MR: Yeah. It's fascinating to think that the dance was the, I guess impetus for the music, but now the music does it all.

HD: Oh yeah. Well I think he got more into, as it became a concert piece you know he said things about the choreography and whatever. You know he had his opinions. He didn't have a great opinion of Bartok which wow, I'm trying not to take offense because I love Bartok. But he had very little good to say about some other composers you know. That was him.

MR: Have you ever wished you could go back, like in a time machine, and be in attendance at a particular musical event?

HD: Oh that one, for sure. And I even thought like you know when I had some grandiose ideas

from the last ten or so years, there is some fictionalized movie of that opening night, but I thought what an amazing thing to be part of. But I think on the other level you know supposedly he took the four-hand thing to Debussy's house and Debussy sight read so I mean that was the level, the level was insane. Plus there's some stuff that Stravinsky really gets from Ravel that are in "The Rite of Spring." There's a piece called Alborada del Gracioso that Ravel did in 1905, and I'm convinced that had to be under Stravinsky's fingers in some way because it's like some remnants that wind — they're in there somewhere. They're Stravinsky-ized but like the pieces that he knew, and I know he was, from what I've read, he was pretty close with Ravel and close enough with Debussy that he wrote "Symphony for Winds" too which is another great piece, as a tribute to Debussy. It doesn't sound at all like Debussy. And then we get to the "Ebony Concerto" which that's his impression of Woody Herman I guess. I mean it's unbelievable.

MR: I had the good fortune to interview Chubby Jackson. And he talked about that, that session, trying to play and Stravinsky's up there. They were so, I think, challenged by that experience.

HD: Hopefully that's the spirit I'm bringing, you know, even when I do my gig tomorrow night. It ain't going to be perfect. And one of the inspiring things, I talked about a few things in the liner notes that inspired me, but when I first heard, because I'd heard denigrating things about the Woody Herman version of "Ebony Concerto." Okay? And then I heard, I got one of these CD collections that had it there and it had some photos of Stravinsky with the guys. And Stravinsky's got his little like PF Flyer looking shoes on and the guys are all dressed up. So Stravinsky's rehearsing that you know, with these guys. And they performed it I think more than once. And it's ragged as hell, but it's great. It's got the spirit. It's got something of that thing that the enthusiasm for the music that's there. Leonard Bernstein in one of the nice YouTube clips where he's teaching "Rite of Srping" to some young people, a great young people's orchestra I think in Germany somewhere, says that it should be played by young people. It doesn't have to be perfect but it's got that energy. And yeah, Stravinsky was 29 so it is a young work. And when it's played maybe over-perfectly it loses some of that edge. So I'm definitely bringing that into it.

MR: Yeah.

HD: It ain't going to be perfect.

MR: Yeah. Congratulations on the recording and — we're approaching about an hour. I have just a couple more things I want to ask you. Two questions about playing with other people. Have you ever had an experience, like you talk about Rich Perry, and he'll play who Rich Perry is. Have you ever had to ask a horn player or someone in your trio or

HD: I think not so much professionally. I used to have a thing with bass players about playing on top of the beat or something, which I'm not, I mean that's not the way I think of it now. But sometimes if somebody was dragging I'd want them to liven it up a little bit. So that was more of a general thing. I think what I told some student saxophone players, especially ones who are terrific technicians and have a lot of chops, it's like you know put some mystery into it. Like I'm not getting you know, at Eastman, one of my groups at Eastman, what do they call it, Dr. Dank Brain and the Mysteriosos or something — because I used to say "make it more mysterious." Miles makes it mysterious. Wayne Shorter makes it mysterious. You don't really know what they're going to do and so sometimes if on the first chorus you're giving out everything and then that second chorus it's like, it sounds a little bit like that, then they're getting the idea you're not organically growing something. So even if you're faking it, because you know what you're going to play but you just kind of hold off a little bit, it sounds more organic. So that's been the thing I told people, to just kind of don't play everything you know, just space it out a little bit, and even compositionally it's the same thing. It's like you write, and I write these things they sound like etudes and whatever. So okay, maybe what if we left some notes out here or there. Or what if, I've gotten to the point where rather than play that thing where you play the head and then you play your solos and the head, I feel like well if I'm going to play a standard maybe I'll play that tune somewhere in the course of the six minutes. Maybe in the middle. Or maybe all fragmented. But you know like you say, like you let the audience know you're playing that tune, but not just do that format thing. So you kind of leave it a little more mysterious. You know and then you create something where it's hopefully satisfying because you're giving — you're giving them that but you're just not giving it in the way that you see it. And I'm kind of doing that with my own pieces too sometimes. And I feel I can do that with my own music. I don't have to play head, solo, and head. I could play it any way I want. You know? Because it's my tune.

MR: Excellent. You anticipated one of my questions and it was about bass players. So I'm going to just wrap up with you know you were at Eastman for eleven plus years and —

HD: Nineteen actually.

MR: Nineteen, that's a big plus. And you dealt with basically what I'll describe as the cream of young musicians. What kind of advice could you give them entering the music field over the years, which you could say I'm not correct in this but it seems like every five or so years certain things go away perhaps to be replaced by something else. But what kind of practical advice could you offer these young people?

HD: Well it's interesting now because so much has changed in the last year with Covid and

finding ways to teach on-line, to get their stuff out there in some way. I think the hardest thing is how music seems to be given away. And you know people put it on-line and then it's up there, it's like it's gone you know. And I mean I used to think of like the hopes of an ASCAP royalty, you know whatever, and I've gotten a little bit with Delos, and I've gotten awards and whatever you get. And it's not a whole lot. But it's still something that has your work protected in some way. And the advice that I would give, and since I'm not really actively teaching now is you've got to be tech savvy, which I am not. And you've got to understand also how to protect yourself, you know, if you want to have a career doing this. There's — you know when you're doing what you love you might not be able to do anything else. That's what I find for myself. But if you're going to do it you've got to find a way that balances the rest of your life, you know whatever you've got, family, and whatever your obligations are, and the fact that you want some future there too. One of the ways I was able to retire is I had a small pension from playing a bunch of hotel cocktail piano that I hadn't forgotten about but you know I'd gotten vested in the union in New York by doing, not Broadway shows or record dates but just playing solo piano, playing my music really quietly to people who weren't listening, and playing Wayne Shorter and practicing and doing whatever. And now it kind of offsets most of the health insurance that I'm dealing with. But those kind of things, I never thought of that, but you know from doing gig after gig which, you know I came up in a time when I was playing five or six nights a week, sometimes seven, and then teaching. I don't know how to give advice on how to do something like that because I don't know that the venues — I know right now they don't exist, we're hoping some of them come back. It seems like the pay scale is the same as it was in 1970, but that's another whole story. But I think the people that want to do it somehow make their way. And it's very, it can be very precarious, but if you love it you'll find a way to keep doing it.

MR: Well said. So thank you very much, it's been a fascinating conversation.

HD: Thank you, Monk. Really happy to do this.

MR: I'm going to pause our recording here and then we'll talk some more about Stravinsky.

HD: Okay.